

What is kano analysis?

The Kano Analysis model (pronounced “Kah-no”), also known as the “Customer Delight vs. Implementation Investment” approach, is an analysis tool that enables you to understand how customer emotional responses to products or features can be measured and explored.

Using a Kano model questionnaire (used to conduct customer-focussed research), product features are categorised across two-axis scales: satisfaction and functionality. With this, businesses can prioritise features on a product roadmap based on how likely they are to satisfy customers and the implementation investment.

This is a much more strategic, customer-oriented approach to product development.

The origins of Kano analysis: Dr. Noriaki Kano

The kano analysis model was published by Dr. Noriaki Kano, professor of quality management at the Tokyo University of Science, in 1984.

At the time, complaint processing and enhancing popular features was the accepted way of improving customer loyalty. Kano wanted to see if there were other ways for brands to maintain and improve customer loyalty levels.

He believed that customer loyalty depended on emotional response levels to features. He hypothesised that there were **five emotional response types to features**, and conducted a study with 900 participants to explore his theory. With his results, he created the kano reaction graph (below), which visualises the five emotional responses as curves.

With this reaction graph, he was able to prove that customer satisfaction depends on how sophisticated an available function is, which in turn causes a more emotional response.

Kano's Five Emotional Response Types

1. Must-be (or must have) features
2. Performance features
3. Attractive features
4. Indifferent features
5. Reverse features

When would you use kano analysis?

Wondering when to use the kano model? Here's when it would be most effective and useful for your business:

- **When there is a limited time**

When product teams are working to tight deadlines, the kano model is a great tool to speed up decision-making.

- **When there are limited resources**

The simple method for carrying out Kano analysis uses an email questionnaire, meaning that you don't need expert resources to do the research.

- **When you want to see what would impress your customers**

When you're looking to 'think outside of the box or 'think big, you can use kano analysis to see what features customers would like and find useful.

- **When you want to enhance a current product**

When it's time to refresh the product or keep it competitive against your market competition, using Kano analysis will assess all your feature options and give you clear choices to pick.

What are The Advantages of Kano Model?

The Kano Model directs product teams to focus on what really matters to your users. Instead of guessing which features you should prioritize, the Kano Model

tasks your product teams to build features that actually cause satisfaction and lead to long-term value.

1. **What's Important:** The Kano Model filters out the nonsense. It helps your team find the features that drive satisfaction and the items that are the "nice to haves." You will spend less time guessing and more time building real value.
2. **Saves Time, Money, and Bandwidth:** By eliminating the work on unnecessary features, your team can focus their time where it matters. One less wasted sprint, one less item on the [product backlog](#), one less item on the overall roadmap.
3. **Establishes Clear Priority Levels:** Kano model categorizes features into five areas as follows: Must-Have, Exciting, Performance, Indifferent, and Reverse. This level of transparency ensures that teams do not get hung up with endless debates about the merits of ideas and find common ground quickly when it comes to determining priority.
4. **Increases Customer Delight:** When you design for how the customer feels, not just what they say, you inevitably create a more delightful product. When the user is delighted, they don't just stay—they promote your product.
5. **Bridge Between Product and Customer Empathy:** The Kano Model turns metrics into empathy as it connects quantitative results (scores, responses, etc.) to the emotional "why" behind the data in a way that provides teams with an even mannered balance between scoring and stories.
6. **Promotes Solid Strategic Decision-Making:** Rather than relying on gut feelings, [product managers](#) can make trade-offs assured by real customer insight. This applies a scientific process to the art of prioritization.
7. **Promotes Innovation Without Risk:** Increase thinking outside-the-box using the “Attractive” (Delighter) category, adding creative features that will delight users while being smart about it, without massive untested ideation investment.
8. **Promotes Collaboration Across Teams:** Kano visualizations help design and development teams, and marketing agree on terms of what's most valuable, reducing friction and disagreement.
9. **Enhances Product Value Over Life:** The model can retain relevance in a product's life cycle because it balances critical features with delight factors—and adds both utility and emotional connectivity.

10. Aligns with Your Organizational Growth: Whether a startup evaluating your MVP, or an enterprise developing a mature product, the Kano Model aligns effortlessly with your growth. Lessons to align the Kano income model may evolve as customer expectations evolve.

Converts Feedback Into Actionable Insights: Instead of relatively vague feedback like "I wish it was easier," the Kano survey gives you tangible signals about what to build, modify or retire... so you can make data and empathy-based decisions.

Kano Model Disadvantages

Although the Kano Model is a useful framework for measuring customer satisfaction, there are a few limitations that teams should be aware of before using it.

1. **Mostly Quantitative:** Survey responses yield lots of categories and numbers, which are unlikely to illuminate why users feel the way they do. You will still need to do qualitative research (i.e., interviews, usability tests) to get to the heart of users' true motivations.
2. **Needs to Be Carefully Analyzed:** The findings are not straightforward. In order to accurately interpret those findings, one requires experience and understanding of user psychology. Otherwise, a team may mis-categorize features and mis-prioritize work.
3. **Takes Time to Execute:** Designing, sending, and analyzing the survey can take an extensive amount of time, especially for large groups of users or products that are more complicated.
4. **Challenging to Manage Manually:** Without digital tools, handling large sets of Kano responses manually can get messy and hard to compare. Automation or analytics software can make this process smoother.
5. **Customer Expectations Change:** What delights users today may very well be a baseline expectation tomorrow. Teams need to regularly revisit their Kano assessments, as [user needs](#) tend to change over time.

How does Kano analysis work?

Kano confirms that a product's customer loyalty level is defined by the customer's emotional responses to its features. But the functionality of the product isn't the only factor that makes it 'good' – emotions matter too.

In general, products can work well and fulfil the basic need it's required for (e.g. a customer can use it to complete a task, such as using a car's key to start its engine), but that may not be enough.

A product that works and fulfils its purpose can still be boring or 'behind the curve'. For example, a car that has self-driving functionality is more impressive, goes beyond the basic needs, and makes a customer think 'wow'.

Taking this approach, product teams can quickly increase their customers' satisfaction level by launching a few great, new features, rather than lots of basic ones. The kano model helps you to prioritise which of these ideas are most valuable, so you can make effective business decisions on which to move forward with.

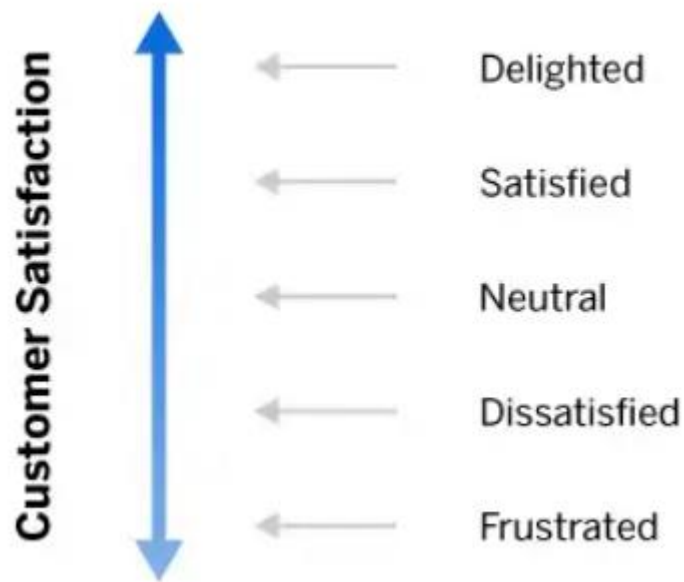
Satisfaction and functionality in the kano analysis model categories

To understand how the kano reaction graph works, it's important to understand satisfaction and functionality. The two below appear within the model as measurement scales to understand the customer's response to a feature.

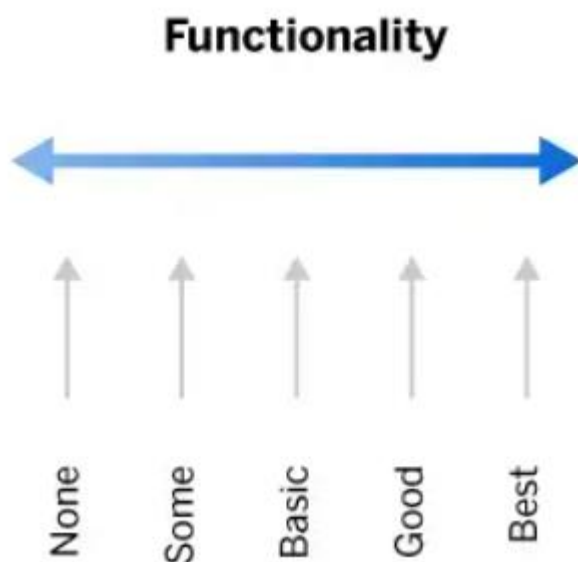
Kano created a satisfaction scale to run from 'Delighted' (indicating high satisfaction or excitement) to 'Frustrated' (indicating low or no satisfaction).

In addition, Kano created a functionality scale (also known as the Investment, Sophistication, or Implementation scale) that runs from 'None' to 'Best'. This represents what level of function the customer thinks a feature provides. Has the feature been implemented to the highest level? Is this feature emotionally well-received by the customer?

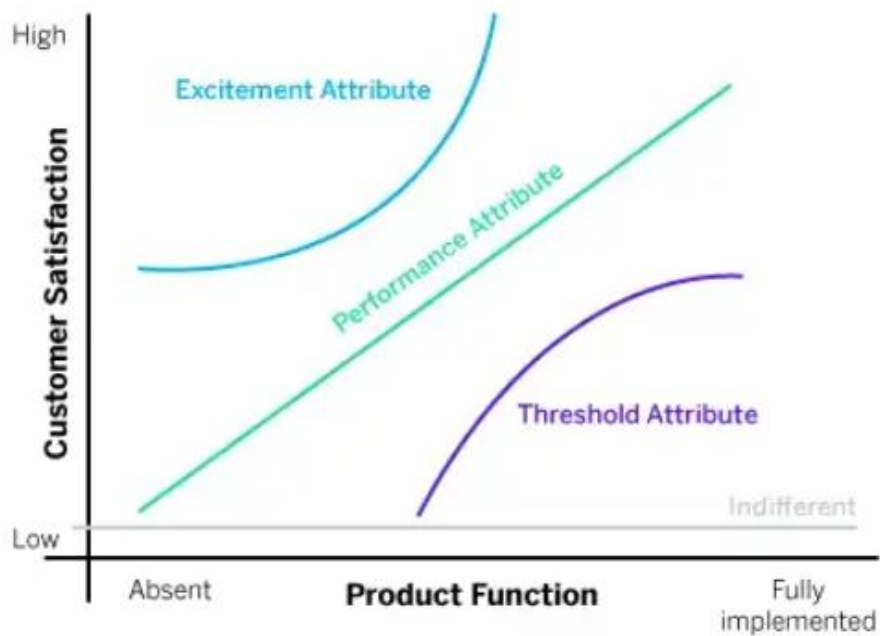
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Based on responses from the kano questionnaire, features can be plotted on the kano reaction graph based on its satisfaction and function level:



The Five Categories of Features in kano analysis

Now that we know the scales of measurement for each feature, next is the feature categories.

There are five categories of features that represent five potential customer reactions to a feature

Kano Requirements Type Definitions: A Summary

Requirements Type	Definition
Must Be (Expected Quality)	Requirement that can dissatisfy (expected, but cannot increase satisfaction)
One-Dimensional (Desired Quality)	The more of these requirements that are met, the more a client is satisfied
Delighters (Excited Quality)	If the requirement is absent, it does not cause dissatisfaction, but it will delight clients if present
Indifferent	Client is indifferent to whether the feature is present or not
Reverse	Feature actually causes dissatisfaction

Must-be features

- Associated with the Threshold Attribute line on the Kano graph
- Must-be are basic features that customers expect a product or service to have.
- These are considered basic features that are expected to be part of the product or service by default. E.g. A customer expects that their hotel room will be clean and have a comfortable bed.
- If these features are there, the customer is likely to be neutral about them. Having these features won't likely add more satisfaction.
- The absence of these qualities will cause dissatisfaction.

Performance features

- Associated to the Performance Attribute line on the Kano graph
- Performance features are desired features that customers want to have to add to their enjoyment of the product or feature, e.g. A car that has a large gas storage tank is considered to store more gas at one time, meaning it performs better than a car that has a smaller gas storage tank.

- If there are a lot of performance features, then customer satisfaction increases in response. Kano described performance features as 'one-directional', as they increase the satisfaction and functionality upwards.

Attractive features

- Associated to the Excitement Attribute line on the Kano graph
- Attractive features are features that cause excitement or delight customers, which sets your product or service above your competition, e.g. Getting a free second product as part of purchasing the first product is not expected but is a delightfully attractive offer that the customer can't get from other competitors.
- Attractive features give satisfaction when they are there, but they don't cause dissatisfaction when they aren't there as they aren't expected to be part of the product in the first place.

Indifferent features

- Associated to the Indifferent Attribute line on the Kano graph
- Indifferent features are features that customers think are neither good nor bad. They can be unimportant features to the customer, e.g. The font-face type used on a product's logo
- Indifferent features don't create satisfaction or dissatisfaction. They're features that are hardly noticed and don't make a difference to the customer.

Reverse features

- Not associated with any lines on the Kano graph, but has the power to impact satisfaction levels.
- Reverse features are features that can cause dissatisfaction and can be considered undesired features by some people, e.g. The visual formatting in an instruction manual can cause dissatisfaction with customers that prefer a step-by-step text instruction format.

A product team should include more must-be, performance, and attractive features and try to avoid indifferent and reverse features.

When to Use the Kano Model in Product Management?

The Kano Model is ideal for application when resource or clarity is restricted. The following is an overview of when it is most effective for your team:

- **When Resources Are Limited:** You simply do not need a large amount of budgets or research teams. Many use any means, just getting a simple customer questionnaire can unveil some powerful stories.
- **To Make Your Customers Feel Amazed:** Use the model to find features that would "wow, astonish, and delight" users. It's helpful for being beyond just anecdotal.
- **Improving an Existing Product:** If your product needs rejuvenation, or you are rushing against many competitors, Kano will be your best friend in addressing impactful features.
- **When Building an MVP:** The Kano Model will guide you in knowing must-haves, performance, and delighter features. A Minimum Viable Product should encompass the basic needs of a customer, but it should not replace delighters in future expansion.
- **When Your Team Needs Clarity:** The Kano model helps prioritize features with coherence and reason. It enables all to know the actual importance of features.
- **When Entering A New Market:** If a product is getting launched for a new demographic, the Kano model reveals what will captivate a demographic.
- **When Developing Or Seeking Agreement Across Teams:** Kano is one language shared across product, design, and marketing, rallying everyone around the idea of what creates happy customers.

While [prioritization frameworks like MoSCoW, RICE, or WSJF](#) frame features around business value or effort, the Kano model applies a third leg of human emotion (customer delight). The framework helps you design experiences that are more meaningful and relevant.

Kano Model Example Analysis

Let's say you ran the survey for your fitness app:

Feature	Kano Category	Takeaway
Automatic Meal Tracking	Attractive	Adds delight—include it for competitive edge
Daily Step Counter	Must-Have	Essential for basic satisfaction
Gamified Challenges	Performance	The more refined, the happier users get
Voice Feedback	Indifferent	Low impact—optional to include
Ads Between Workouts	Reverse	Users dislike it—avoid at all costs

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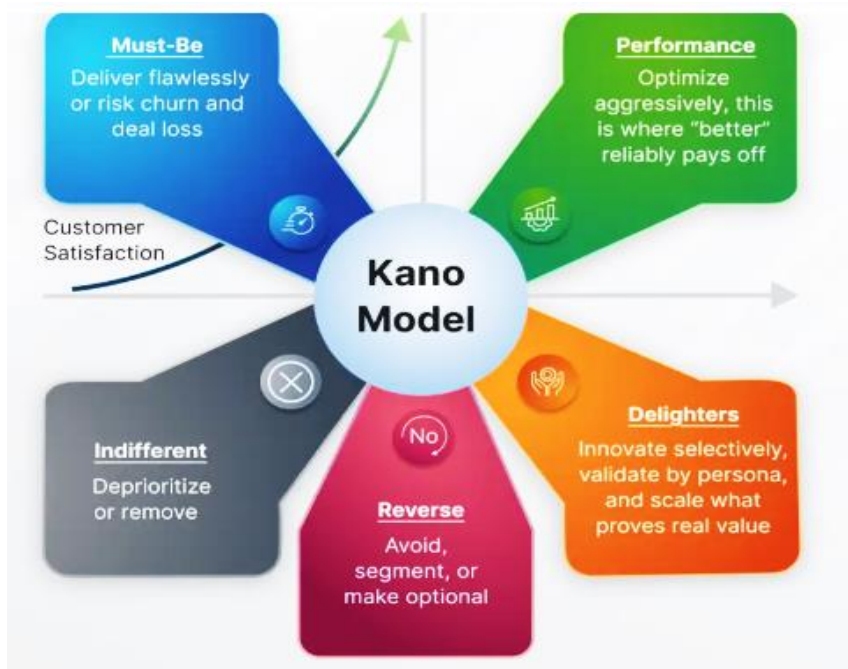
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How Kano Analysis Works?

To analyze features, the Kano model uses two dimensions:

Dimension	Scale	Meaning
Satisfaction	Delighted → Frustrated	How happy or unhappy the customer feels about a feature.
Functionality (or Implementation)	None → Best	How well the feature performs or is implemented.

All features are mapped on the two dimensions to show how they influence customer satisfaction. When you collect the responses after participants complete a Kano questionnaire, they can illustrate the features on the Kano reaction graph - demonstrating which features delight, satisfy, and or dissatisfy customers.



Must-Be (Basic) Features

These are the fundamental requirements customers expect by default. If a must-be feature is missing or fails, customers become dissatisfied. If it's present and functional, customers are simply neutral because they assume it should work. Kano described these as the price of entry into a market.

Example:

Single Sign-On (SSO), role-based access control (RBAC), audit logs, core security, and compliance controls. These are rarely praised when they work, but their absence can trigger immediate rejection in enterprise buying decisions.

In short, these are the "must-haves." Forgetting them is a deal-breaker, while doing them well only meets baseline expectations.

2. Performance (One-Dimensional) Features

These create satisfaction when they're strong and dissatisfaction when they're weak. More is better, less is worse. Customer satisfaction scales with performance.

Example:

Uptime reliability, API stability, latency, reporting speed, search accuracy, and workflow efficiency. Customers explicitly ask for these improvements, and competitors often fight on these dimensions.

These are typically where incremental investment produces predictable gains in customer satisfaction and retention.

3. Delighters (Excitement) Features

These surprise and delight customers when present, but their absence doesn't cause dissatisfaction. They're unspoken "extras" that customers don't necessarily expect until someone delivers them well.

Example:

Smart automation that removes manual steps, context-aware insights ("here's the next best action"), proactive anomaly alerts, or AI summaries that actually save time without creating risk.

Delighters can create strong differentiation, but only if validated with the right personas. In enterprise products, a delighter for end users may be indifferent (or even risky) for compliance or IT stakeholders.

4. Indifferent Features

These have little or no effect on satisfaction. Whether present or absent, customers don't care.

Examples:

Cosmetic admin UI tweaks, minor theme changes nobody requested, low-usage dashboard widgets, or "nice-to-have" settings that don't improve outcomes.

Identifying indifferent features is valuable because they are prime candidates for cutting or saving costs, reducing product bloat, and protecting roadmap focus.

5. Reverse Features

These cause dissatisfaction when present. A feature may be appealing to one segment but irritating or risky to another.

Examples:

Forced AI workflows, intrusive automation that removes user control, aggressive in-app upsells, or mandatory “assistant” features that disrupt established processes.

Reverse features should usually be avoided or made optional. The right strategy is often segmentation + opt-in, not a one-size-fits-all rollout.

How the Kano Model Works

Kano analysis is driven by customer feedback using a paired-question survey. For each proposed feature, customers (or target users) answer:

- **Functional Question:** “How would you feel if [feature] were present in the product?”
- **Dysfunctional Question:** “How would you feel if [feature] were not present?”

Each question uses five standard response options: I like it, I expect it, I am neutral, I can tolerate it, I dislike it.

The combination of answers determines the Kano category. For example, if a customer likes a feature when present and dislikes it when absent, it typically indicates a Performance (One-dimensional) feature. If they like it when present but feel neutral when absent, it suggests a Delighter (Attractive).

Kano Questionnaire Format

Question Type	Sample Question	Response Options
Functional	"How would you feel if [Feature] is present?"	1. I like it 2. I expect it 3. I'm neutral 4. I can tolerate it 5. I dislike it
Dysfunctional	"How would you feel if [Feature] is not present?"	1. I like it 2. I expect it 3. I'm neutral 4. I can tolerate it 5. I dislike it

Kano Evaluation Matrix

Note: A = Attractive (Delighter), O = One-dimensional (Performance), M = Must-Be, I = Indifferent, R = Reverse, Q = Questionable.

Functional \ Dysfunctional	I like it	I expect it	I am neutral	I can live with it	I dislike it
I like it	Q	A	A	A	O
I expect it	It should be that way	R	I	I	I
I am neutral	M	R	I	I	I
I can live with it	M	R	I	I	I
I dislike it	M	R	R	R	Q

After collecting responses, count how many answers fall into each category for every feature. The dominant category typically becomes the feature's overall classification, which then guides prioritization and roadmap decisions.

The Kano Model Formula & Calculations

Beyond categorization, Kano can quantify how strongly a feature influences satisfaction. A common approach is to compute Better (satisfaction) and Worse (dissatisfaction) coefficients using survey tallies.

First, define:

Formula:	$\text{Total} = \text{Delighters} + \text{Performance} + \text{Must-Be} + \text{Indifferent}$
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Then calculate:

Formula:	$\text{Better} = (\text{Delighters} + \text{Performance}) / \text{total}$ $\text{Worse} = -(\text{Performance} + \text{Must-Be}) / \text{total}$
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How to interpret these scores:

- A higher Better score suggests the feature is more likely to increase satisfaction when present
- A Worse score closer to -1 suggests the feature is more likely to cause dissatisfaction if missing
- If Better is high and Worse is strongly negative, the feature often behaves like a Performance attribute
- If Better is high but Worse is close to 0, it often behaves like a Delighter
- If Worse is strongly negative but Better is low, it often behaves like a Must-Be

By ranking features on both the Better and Worse, teams build a prioritization matrix.

Step-by-Step Guide: Implementing Kano Analysis

Implementing Kano analysis involves these key steps:

1. Define Your Objectives. Clarify what you want to achieve. Are you launching a new product, adding features, or improving an existing product? Setting goals (e.g., “increase retention by 10%”) guides the evaluation of which features to prioritize. Align with stakeholders on success metrics and scope (e.g., feature list, target user group) to ensure alignment and clarity of objectives.

2. Identify Features to Evaluate. List potential features or attributes relevant to customers. Include basic expectations (e.g., login, help center), performance candidates (e.g., faster load times), and innovative ideas (e.g., AI assistance). Brainstorm with cross-functional teams and sift through customer feedback to compile a comprehensive feature list.

3. Design Your Kano Questionnaire. For each feature, craft a functional question and a dysfunctional question (see table above). Use clear, non-technical language that customers will understand. Pre-test your survey with a small internal group. Draft questions, then refine the wording so that the meaning of each feature is obvious. Make sure to include consistent response options (like/dislike scale).

4. Collect Customer Responses. Distribute the Kano survey to real customers or target users. Methods can include email surveys, in-app questionnaires, or live interviews. Aim for a statistically meaningful sample (often at least 100–200 responses for mid-sized products). Launch the survey, set a deadline, and send reminders. Provide an incentive (discount, gift card) to boost participation. Ensure diverse respondents representing your target market.

5. Analyze and Categorize Results. Tabulate responses for each feature. Map each respondent’s paired answers onto the Kano evaluation matrix. The category with the most votes typically defines the feature’s classification. Create a spreadsheet tally. Mark each feature as Must-Be, Performance, Delighter, Indifferent, or Reverse. If needed, label any ambiguous cases as “Questionable” and consider further study.

6. Calculate Better-Worse Coefficients. Use the formulas from above to compute each feature’s Better (satisfaction) and Worse (dissatisfaction) scores. This quantifies each feature’s impact. For each feature, sum the counts of Delighter, Performance, Must-Be, and Indifferent votes. Compute the coefficients. This step converts categorical Kano results into numbers you can graph or rank.

7. Prioritize Features. Rank features based on category and coefficients. Generally, focus first on performance and delighter features with high Better scores (to drive satisfaction) and on must-be features with low Worse scores (to prevent dissatisfaction). Low-impact features (Indifferent or low Better/Worse) go lower on the backlog.

Sample of Feature Prioritization Matrix:

Feature	Category	Better (Score)	Worse (Score)	Priority	Action
Real-Time Collaboration	Performance	0.80	-0.45	High	Develop Immediately
Offline Mode	Delighter	0.60	-0.10	Medium	Consider if the budget permits
Custom Themes	Delighter	0.30	0.00	Low	Pipeline
Tutorial Overlays	Indifferent	0.10	-0.05	Low	Defer
Auto-Play Videos	Reverse	0.00	-0.80	High	Remove the feature or make it opt-in

In this example, Real-Time Collaboration (Performance) and Advanced Reporting have the highest priority; they both greatly boost satisfaction (Better high) and prevent dissatisfaction if absent (Worse significant). Auto-Play Videos is flagged as Reverse: development would likely annoy users, so it is slated for removal.

8. Action Plan & Continuous Review. With priorities set, update your product roadmap—plan development sprints around the Kano findings. But remember: customer expectations evolve. Schedule periodic Kano reviews (see Advanced section below) to adjust priorities over time. Assign owners to each feature, set deadlines, and monitor key metrics (customer satisfaction scores, adoption rates). After releasing features, retest customer satisfaction to measure the impact. By following these steps, teams transform Kano analysis from raw survey data into a clear, actionable product strategy. The visual feature prioritization matrix above provides a quick way to share decisions with stakeholders.

Kano model: Customer satisfaction coefficients

A further technique is to measure the extent of customer satisfaction (CS) with the CS⁺ and CS⁻ coefficients. These are employed as follows:

$$CS^+ = \frac{\text{excitement} + \text{performance}}{\text{excitement} + \text{performance} + \text{threshold} + \text{indifferent}}$$

$$CS^+ = \frac{A + O}{A + O + M + U}$$

$$CS^- = (-1) * \frac{\text{performance} + \text{threshold}}{\text{excitement} + \text{performance} + \text{threshold} + \text{indifferent}}$$

$$CS^- = (-1) * \frac{O + M}{A + O + M + U}$$

Figure 6: Satisfaction and dissatisfaction coefficients for a Kano model

$$\text{Better} = \frac{A + O}{A + O + M + I}$$

$$\text{Worse} = - \frac{O + M}{A + O + M + I}$$

The Kano Model uses math for prioritizing features by categorizing them (Must-be, Performance, Attractive, Indifferent, Reverse) via surveys, then calculating satisfaction scores using formulas like

Calculate Kano Coefficient (K): Use counts (A=Attractive, O=One-dim, M=Must-be, I=Indifferent, R=Reverse).

$$K = (A + O - M - R) / (A + O + M + R)$$

Interpretation:

K > 0: Feature is desirable (more A, O than M, R).

K < 0: Feature causes dissatisfaction (more M, R than A, O).

K near 1: Pure Attractive (delights).

K near 0: Indifferent or Must-be (basic/expected).

No	Attribute	Kano Category					
		A	O	M	I	R	Q
1	Generator Price	4	3	3	4	1	0
2	Operation Cost	2	1	7	5	0	0
3	Safety Factor	1	4	6	4	0	0
4	Ease of Operation	2	5	4	4	0	0
5	Durability	1	6	5	2	1	0
6	Enviromental Impact	1	3	6	5	0	0
7	Output of Energy	2	2	7	4	0	0
8	Aesthetics	2	3	1	8	1	0

From the above table, the next step to determine the Kano category

$(A+O)/(A+O+M+I)$

(for positive signals) to get a value between -1 (dissatisfied) and +1 (delighted), guiding product development for maximum impact, often integrated with Quality Function Deployment (QFD).

Key Kano Categories & Examples

- **Must-be (Basic/M)**: Expected, taken for granted (e.g., functional brakes in a car, clean hotel room).
- **Performance (One-Dimensional/O)**: More is better (e.g., fuel efficiency, faster internet speed).
- **Attractive (Excitement/A)**: Unexpected delights (e.g., a surprise free upgrade, advanced software feature).
- **Indifferent (I)**: Doesn't matter to satisfaction (e.g., carpet color in a hotel).
- **Reverse (R)**: Presence causes dissatisfaction (rare, e.g., too many pop-up ads).

Mathematical Calculation (Fekry et al., 2014)

1. **Survey**: Ask customers two questions per feature: "How do you feel if the feature is present?" (Functional form) and "How do you feel if the feature is absent?" (Dysfunctional form) using options like "I like it," "I expect it," "I'm neutral," "I dislike it," "I hate it."
2. **Categorization**: Map responses to the Kano categories (A, O, M, I, R) using a standard table.
3. **Calculate Satisfaction Score (k)**:
 - **Positive Signal (presence)**: $(A+O)/(A+O+M+I)$
 - **Negative Signal (absence)**: $(O+M)/(A+O+M+I)$

- **Overall Score:** Combine results to get a value from -1 (dissatisfied) to +1 (delighted).

Example Application

- **Product:** A new smartphone.
- **Feature:** "Night Mode" camera feature.
- **Survey:**
 - *Present:* "I love it!" (A)
 - *Absent:* "I'd be disappointed" (M)
- **Category:** "Attractive" (A).
- **Math:** If most users are A/M, it's a strong delight feature (A), but if they're A/A, it's a strong performance feature (O). The score helps prioritize building it.